

HUMANITARIAN INFORMATION, RESSOURCE CENTERS IN AFRICA AND RELATED ACTIVITIES.

1. **ETHIOPIA** – To improve the quality and timeliness of humanitarian information and to promote information sharing practices in the HOA, the UNOCHA has initiated the establishment of **Common Humanitarian Information Network (CHIN) for the Horn of Africa**. A team of experts in Ethiopia is composed of the Project Coordinator, Institutional Specialist, System Analyst/Senior Programmer and Database Expert. The Team has already laid down some of the technical and institutional foundations for information networking in Ethiopia, which will be partly replicable to other countries of the Horn.
 - The activity is linked to the continuation of the functions of the ORHC.
 - Mr. Watkins is currently providing technical support to the Eritrea ICC and collaborated in the preparation of the Kenya workshop.
 - The major focus of the activities of CHIN is in the development of a regional humanitarian contact database, humanitarian resource tracking data base (who is doing what and where and with what resources) and a Meta data dictionary data base (who has what information and where to go and get it).
2. **ERITREA: - The Information Co-ordination Centre (ICC)** was established in May 2000. The aim of the ICC is to promote close collaboration, information sharing and co-ordination between all humanitarian actors, UN agencies, the Eritrean Relief and Refugee Commission (ERREC) and Non-Governmental Organisations (NGOs). The ICC is staffed and funded by different agencies, further promoting the underlying concept of an inter-agency approach.
 - The ICC operates under the auspices of ERREC and the UN
 - In 2001, once expansion of the ICC has been consolidated, the focus will shift to capacity building and transition
 - The last portion in the expansion of the ICC is the GIS capacity, currently under development. Mr. Craig Williams is being contracted to support for three months the training of qualified local staff and develop the pcoding system. (During the same consultancy we expect that Mr. Williams will develop the PCODING guidelines as part of the SHARE concept).
3. **KENYA: -** The purpose of the recently held workshop was to reach a consensus on the establishment of a facility and network for promoting data and information exchange in the Horn of Africa. The facility has been named “Humanitarian Assistance Information Center (HAIC)”, although this name may change. The HAIC is intended to provide a mechanism to support GIS and remote sensing data exchange between humanitarian partners in the region, and with international bodies. The facility should be fully demand-driven, responding to the partner’s specific needs. One of its most basic functions is to promote basic standards for the exchange of spatial data.
 - The US department of State, office of the geographer has provided a Humanitarian Planning Map to the HAIC secretariat, a digital product with regional coverage. (The UNDP Somalia information unit has the technical capacity to manage the data product).
 - UNEP has agreed to provide office space, equipment and communications for the project
 - UNHCR has one GIS expert that would be deployed in support of the activities of the center

Current status of the HAIC and decisions taken during the workshop:

There will be a three-month start up and definition stage during which the following actions will be undertaken:

- ◆ Establish a representative Steering Committee including UN, NGOs, and Donor representation
- ◆ Conduct in depth requirement assessment

- ◆ Formulate project document (terms of reference developed, funding...)
- ◆ Formulate a work plan, identifying critical short-term and long-term activities
- ◆ Establish a network
- ◆ Establish a website, initially with limited access for those currently involved including an interactive Q&A/discussion page
- ◆ Use currently available resources (UNEP for office space) in this phase
- ◆ Define administrative arrangements for the facility.
- ◆ Define the geographical scope of pilot activities
- ◆ Determine name, suggested to be action oriented i.e. Sharing Information for Humanitarian Action SIHA, suggested **facility** rather than **center**...?
- ◆ Establish links with IGAD specifically with their planned Regional Integrated Information System (RIIS), assessing complementarities and potential for shared resources
- ◆ Draw lessons from ongoing assessments and other materials on Humanitarian Information Centers elsewhere in the world.

SIERRA LEONE: - The activity builds on the existing Humanitarian Information Center (HIC) in Sierra Leone by improving the timely use of existing information by those who can benefit from it. Its three-pronged approach includes a) creating a common framework in which existing information can fit and which will be used in future information gathering, b) facilitating exchange of information, particularly by using this common framework, and c) mainstreaming technological shortcuts to improve the quality of geographical information. The basic products of the center will be a common digital map a library of assessments an assistance information system a refugees and IDPs information system.

- UNHCR is funding the GIS and data base expert identified by OCHA, (Ms. Kathleen Miner)
- OCHA has requested ECHO support for the provision of the equipment for the center.
- The DPKO GIS pilot project has lined up support for the center
- The center will support similar activities in the nearby region.
- The US / DOS has produced an HPM product for the region that is to be released soon

4. **MOZAMBIQUE:** - In order to contribute to the process of contingency planning and preparedness for Mozambique in support of the RC and the UNCT, OCHA with the support of DFID fielded an experienced technical person from the Field Information Support project (FIS) to work on the information management aspects of the plan. Mr. Romano has been in Maputo now for three weeks.

- The data base related to the rapid assessment process is being finalized
- The Peoding and village naming protocols are being finalized
- The Information manager is in contact with the Gaberone based regional preparedness center where OCHA (DRB) intends to place a disaster response regional advisor to look into the possibility of maintaining a GIS / remote sensing capacity for the region.
- The Information manager has a six months contract funded through DIFD in support of the RC and the UNCT
- The officer is housed by WFP that also provides communications and equipment
- The USAID/FEWS project is working closely with the team to implement a generalized flood model for the various at risk areas.

LINKS:

Ethiopia, Kenya and Eritrea are linked in several ways:

- Sharing complementary technical capacities, **Ethiopia** concentrates on database development (coding, reverse engineering of existing applications, links between applications). **Kenya** has the capacity to develop the GIS and remote sensing capabilities (will concentrate on the customization distribution and maintenance of the HPM product and with the initial treatment of remote sensing imagery in time of crisis).
- **Eritrea** is the recipient of all the support that these two “regional capacities” can provide, Mr. Watkins is currently in Asmara providing technical support in the development of their data base structure.

Sierra Leone:

- The GIS officer to be deployed in the HIC will provide technical support to the data base specialist based in Guinea and to the office in Cote D’Ivoire.
- Will customize, maintain and distribute the HPM to the region.
- Will develop mapping products in support of the region.
- Will link with the DPKO – Pilot GIS project, sharing technical capacities and products (The British contingent has been contacted and agrees in principle to provide paper mapping support)

Mozambique:

- If the decision were made to provide data base, GIS and remote sensing support and products to the regional disaster advisor, these capacities would be available to the countries of the region also in the area of preparedness.
- USAID/ FEWS and USGS working closely with Mr. Romano on the development of the flooding model for the region that could be used by all other centers.